

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

ments, but they had to let other expenses back up. In about a year they found themselves deeply in debt. They couldn't even afford to keep their old car repaired since it took nearly \$75 a month to keep it running. So they bought a new car at \$275 a month. In another six months, they couldn't keep their mortgage payments current. There was not enough money to even buy the essentials. Since there seemed to be no other choice at that point, Ann decided she had to go to work. They were certain that more income would be the solution.

Their income increased a little, but their expenses increased even more. There was more eating out, more clothes, another car. Within another year, they had consumed her salary and were deeper in debt than ever before.

It is at this point where most couples decide to consolidate their bills. Don and Ann did exactly that. They borrowed from their parents to consolidate and pay off their small bills. They even made payments to their parents for a few months. With the pressures of the delinquent bills relieved, they assumed the problems were solved. Not so. With a house payment too high for their budget and two car loans, they fell right back into the same spending habits, and within a year, they had all of the little bills back again *plus* the consolidation loan.

By this time, they were having daily arguments about money and Ann was feeling great anxiety as they drifted deeper into debt. Their Bible study as well as their prayer time together were down to zero. They didn't talk anymore. They argued about virtually everything, even nonfinancial matters. Creditors pressured Ann at home and at work with phone calls and certified collection letters. Usually creditors attempt to contact the wife, if possible, because they know if they pressure her, she'll pressure her husband.

If not corrected quickly, such a financial nightmare situation can lead to severe marriage problems. In Don and Ann's case, it led to a divorce that neither ever thought could happen. Their mistake of buying too expensive a home was compounded by treating the symptoms it created. Most couples can avoid these consequences, but only if they decide to deal with